

The Australian nobody can ignore now

Quillan Salkilld is no longer merely a promising Australian prospect. After dispatching Mateusz Gamrot, he has **forced his way** into the UFC lightweight conversation.

Nigamanth P

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

Quillan Salkilld, yes, the same Salkilld who knocked out India's Anshul Jubli in 19 seconds, is becoming a household name in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC).

He strengthened his credentials as a serious lightweight contender with a statement victory over Mateusz Gamrot in the main event of UFC Fight Night at the Meta APEX in Las Vegas.

The 26-year-old Australian submitted the No. 8-ranked Gamrot via rear-naked choke at 4:25 of the opening round. The victory

extended his winning streak to 13 fights and maintained his unbeaten record inside the UFC.

The result marked Salkilld's sixth consecutive UFC victory and his fourth straight stoppage.

The former KSW champion was expected to provide Salkilld with his toughest test, but the Australian produced perhaps the biggest win of his career.

Gamrot initially threatened with a heel-hook attempt, but Salkilld escaped and quickly began finding

success on the feet. His jab repeatedly found its mark. A straight punch then appeared to hurt Gamrot, forcing the Polish veteran into a takedown attempt.

Salkilld then turned the tables on the ground. After securing a takedown of his own, he worked his way to Gamrot's back and held the position through several scrambles. He eventually got both hooks in and locked up the rear-naked choke, forcing Gamrot to tap with 35 seconds remaining in the opening round.

The victory puts Salkilld firmly in the lightweight title contender conversation.

After the fight, he made it clear that he wants a top-five opponent

Here to stay: One 19-second knockout brought Salkilld to attention. A win over No. 8-ranked Mateusz Gamrot has kept him there. PICS: GETTYIMAGES

